



The façade of a building known as the Nunnery annex, at Chichen Itza, the leading Maya city-state of the Late or Terminal Classic Period.



Symeon of Bulgaria, depicted in the center, had been educated as a monk in Constantinople before returning to take control of the Bulgars in 893.

“WE DISCERN ACROSS THE CENTURIES A **COMMANDING AND VERSATILE INTELLIGENCE**, WIELDING WITH EQUAL FORCE THE SWORD OF **WAR** AND OF **JUSTICE**. ”

Winston Churchill, *British Politician*, on King Alfred, 1956–58

throne pillars overboard and following their drift.

The **Twelfth Imam, al-Mahdi**—believed by some Shi’ites to be the ultimate savior of humankind—miraculously disappeared in 874. According to some Shi’ites, when the Eleventh Imam, Hasan al-Askari, died in 874, his successor, a seven-year-old boy, went into literal and spiritual hiding, and ever since has been said to be “occulted,” or hidden until the day of his **messianic return**.

The **Anglo-Saxon Chronicle**, a unique written record of events from wars and politics to the weather, was kept from around 880 until the mid-12th century. It was indicative of the scholarship that King Alfred fostered, inviting scholars to England and translating major classical works himself.

SWEDISH VIKINGS, known as the **Varangians or Rus**, used rivers such as the **Volga** and **Dnieper** to push ever farther inland from the Baltic, establishing dominion over the **eastern Slavs** of the region. Having **founded the settlement of Novgorod** in 862 and launched audacious raids on Constantinople by navigating rivers all the way to the Black Sea, they now colonized ever farther south. In 882, the Rus **prince Oleg** (r. 882–912) defeated his rivals Askold and Dir, **seized** their settlement at **Kiev**, and transferred his capital there from Novgorod. The city would become the capital of **Kievan Rus**, a loose federation of territories, until 1169.

The **Danelaw**—the part of England in which Viking law was upheld—was formalized by the **Treaty of Alfred and Guthrum** in 886, following renewed attacks by Guthrum. Alfred would keep the south, including London, while the area to the north of a line between the Thames and Lea rivers went to the Danish, who would live under their own laws.

In 887, **Charles the Fat** (c. 839–88), the last Carolingian king to rule both the primary Frankish territories, West and East Francia (modern-day France and Germany), was **deposed**. Charles, already king of the East Franks since 879, had been elected king of the West Franks in 884. However, he was a victim of the declining power and authority of the Carolingian monarchs (see 841–50). Unable or unwilling to meet the Vikings in battle—specifically during their **Siege of**



Slavonic-Viking Jewelry
Viking invaders conquered territories along Russia’s waterways, establishing a hybrid culture that mixed Slavonic and Viking styles.

Paris in 885–86—he was proven incapable of protecting his people. **Odo**, Count of Paris (c. 860–98), who had led a heroic defense against the Vikings in 885, was elected king of West Francia in 887. From now on, East and West Francia would develop as separate regions.

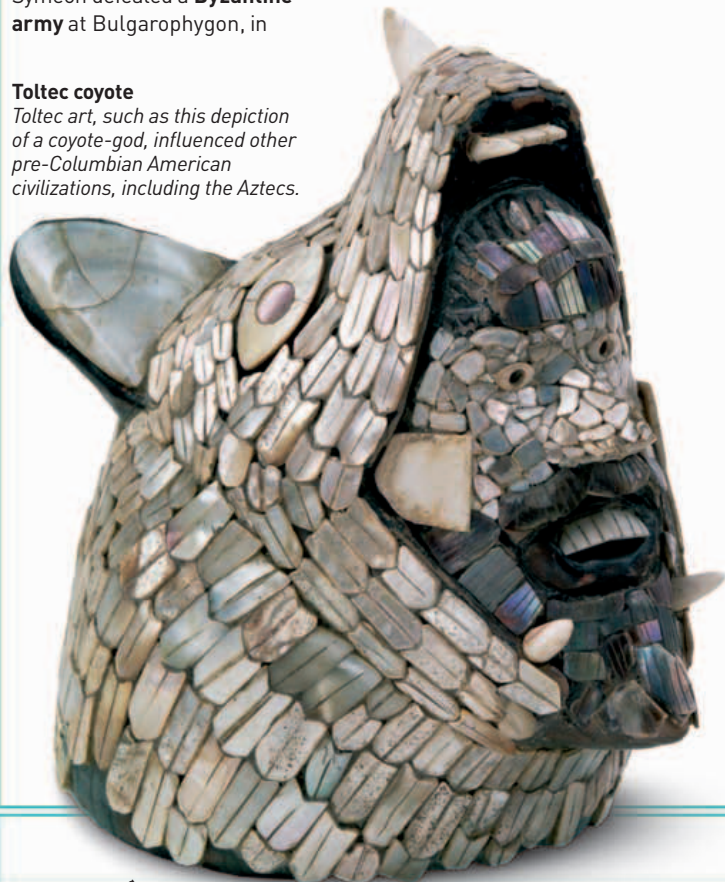
The catastrophic **decline of the Classic Maya city-states** of the southern lowlands continued throughout the 9th century, and **Tikal was abandoned** by around 889. Maya city-states of the north (the area of Mexico’s Yucatán Peninsula) now took precedence in what is known as the Late or Terminal Classic Period. Foremost among these civilizations was **Chichen Itza**, which commanded the advantage of *cenotes*, or water holes; of vital importance in this drought-vulnerable region.

THE GROWING POWER OF THE BULGAR KHANATE (see 811–20) worried the Byzantine emperor **Leo VI**, who in 895 prompted the **Magyars** to attack the Bulgars. However, this merely provoked the new khan, **Symeon** (r. 893–927), to mobilize the Pechenegs—a tribe that had recently arrived on the Dnieper—to invade Magyar lands. The Magyars were forced to migrate west, settling in present-day **Hungary**, from where they launched extensive raids on Frankish territories for years to come. In the summer of 896, Symeon defeated a **Byzantine army** at Bulgarophyon, in

modern-day Turkey, forcing the Byzantine emperor to pay tribute. Symeon would rule for another 30 years, vying for the Byzantine throne, only to be thwarted by the impenetrable walls of its capital, **Constantinople**, on numerous occasions.

The **Toltecs** (c. 800–1000) were probably refugees from the **collapsed Teotihuacan culture** (see 690–700), who settled in the Valley of Mexico, founding a capital at **Tula** c. 900, and forging a militaristic empire that inspired their descendants, the Aztecs.

Toltec coyote
Toltec art, such as this depiction of a coyote-god, influenced other pre-Columbian American civilizations, including the Aztecs.



879 Nepal independent from Tibet

880 War in India between Pandya and Cholas

880 first Anglo-Saxon chronicle written

880 Huang Zhao, peasant rebel turned general, usurps imperial throne from Tang emperor

882 Oleg seizes Kiev, makes it capital of Kievan Rus

884 Huang Zhao of Tang China defeated by Turkic armies, but Tang power shaken

887 Odo crowned King of West Francia

887 Carolingian Charles the Fat deposed

889 Tikal abandoned, Chichen Itza preeminent

896 Beginning of height of Bulgarian Empire under Symeon

899 Death of Alfred the Great of Wessex (b. 849)

c. 900 Development of Toltec kingdom centered on Tula in Valley of Mexico

c. 900 Vikings discover Greenland

c. 900 earliest versions of alf-Layla wa-Layla, “One Thousand and One Nights”